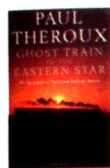


THE TRODDEN TRACK

Travel becomes the saddest of pleasures for Theroux as he relives the great train journey



GHOST TRAIN TO THE EASTERN STAR: ON THE TRACKS OF THE GREAT RAILWAY BAZAAR

by PAUL THEROUX

Hamish Hamilton

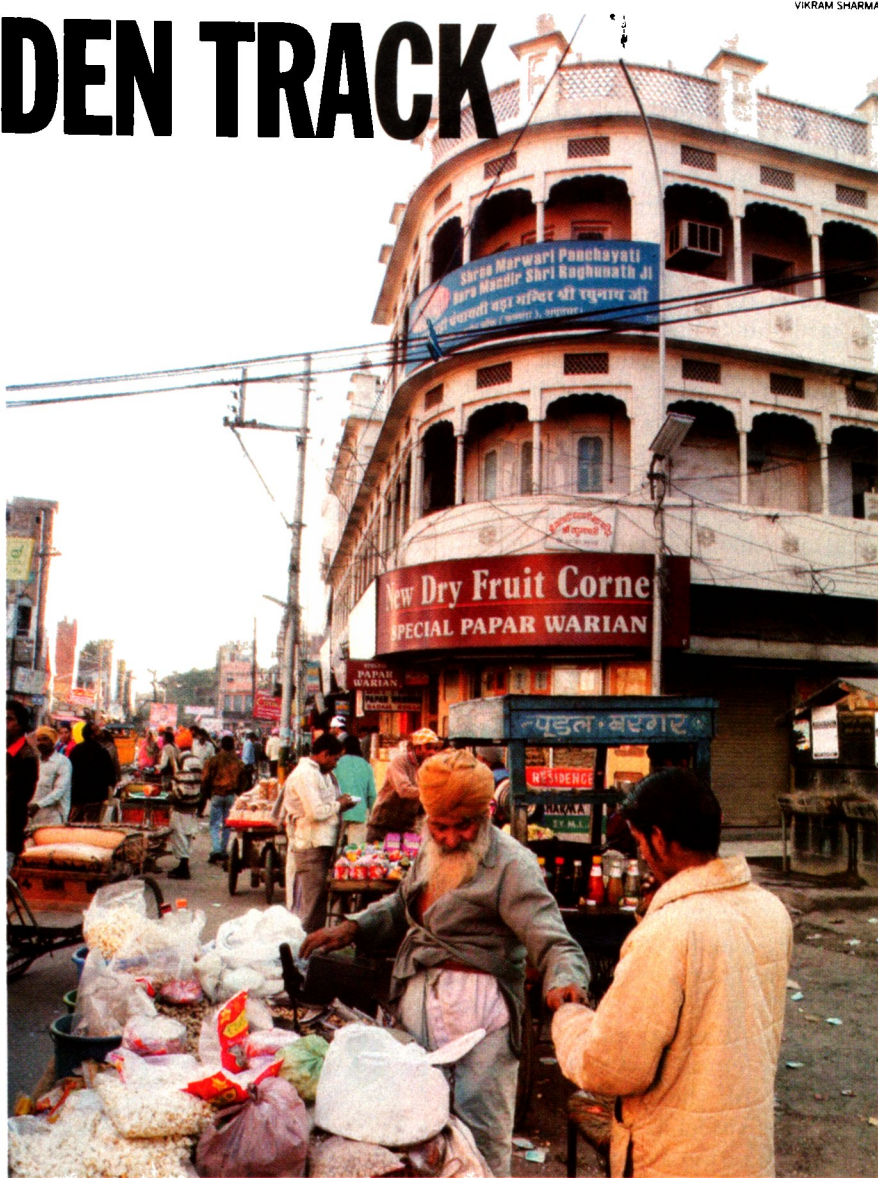
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■ By Sam Miller

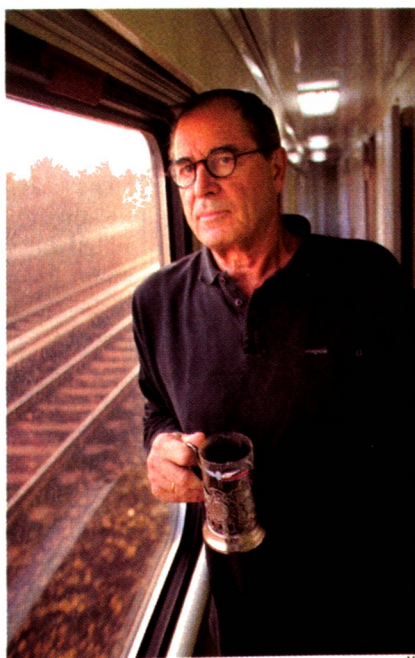
More than 30 years ago, an American writer travelled by train from London to Tokyo, via India, and back again. His book about that journey, *The Great Railway Bazaar*, was a huge success, and heralded a new genre of travel writing in which the journey and the human encounters it involved were more important than history and monuments. Paul Theroux went on to write many more travel books and novels, including a remarkable portrait of his former friend V.S. Naipaul.

Theroux's new book is a strangely muted affair. He decides to repeat the journey of *The Great Railway Bazaar*, with a few route changes—and several extra plane journeys. He is twice as old as he was on his original trip, and a lot grumpier. And although *Ghost Train to the Eastern Star* is perfectly readable, he seems to have lost some of the spark and curiosity that marked his earlier work. He also appears to be in a hurry to get home. He reveals that the jolly tone of *The Great Railway Bazaar* concealed an inner misery. In his absence, his wife had "taken a lover"—and he had realised this while talking to her from faraway Tokyo—one of only two conversations there were able to have during his entire trip. This time he has a BlackBerry. So he can be in constant touch with his second wife, nicknamed Penelope, after the faithful wife of Odysseus. Penelope, he tells us, is at home—knitting.

Theroux, meanwhile, is visiting brothels and chatting—no more than that, of course—with prostitutes. He writes at a greater length about his visit



A TOUGH RIDE: A crowded market in Amritsar; Theroux (left)



to a Bangkok masseuse called Sky than he does about his entire journey through China. He spends a lot of time testing his theory that "a country's pornography offers the quickest insight into the culture and inner life of a nation". Bestiality, he tells us, is big in Hungary, while the Japanese are obsessed with schoolgirls. There are some high-brow moments too. His guides in Istanbul and Tokyo are novelists Orhan Pamuk and Haruki Murakami. He bumps into Charles and Camilla in Jodhpur, and nearly plays ping pong with Arthur C. Clarke in Colombo. He gets excited when he finds someone reading *The Great Railway Bazaar* on a train. But most of the times, he seems